

HARVESTING PURITY Women workers with Jashpure products

A **portmanteau born from the lush**, unspoiled forests of Jashpur in northern Chhattisgarh, Jashpure is more than a brand name. It's the shared identity of over 50 all-women self-help groups (SHGs). Conceived in February 2024 by then district magistrate Ravi Mittal, the initiative tackles the hurdles SHGs face in selling their wares and helps tribal communities find markets for their processed produce. As its name suggests, Jashpure champions purity—a quality easier to preserve in these tribal regions, where the soil remains far less polluted by chemical fertilisers than in the plains.

"The common challenge faced by SHGs in getting their produce to find takers is the lack of long-term handholding, along with certain inadequacies among SHG members in understanding business aspects such as branding, packaging and marketing," says Samarth Jain, 36, director, Jai Jungle Farmer Producer Company, which runs the Jashpure brand. "There is also a lot of paperwork to be done, returns to be filed and permissions to be obtained from state and central agencies for selling food products. These are processes that locals, especially tribals, can neither afford nor navigate. Jashpure seeks to address that gap."

How were these gaps bridged to get Jashpure going? "We began by training SHG members on the basics, such as how to work professionally, why it is important to arrive at work at a fixed time, why lunch